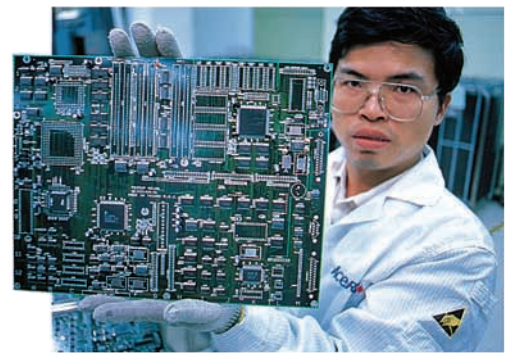




TAIWAN

WHEN PORTUGUESE SAILORS first visited this island in 1590, they named it *Ilha Formosa* – “Beautiful Island” – because of its lush, mountainous scenery. In 1949, at the end of civil war in China, the defeated Nationalist government fled here and established itself as a rival to the communists on the mainland. Taiwan still officially calls itself the Republic of China. Since then, both Taiwan and China have tried to seek international recognition as the official Chinese government. However, few nations recognize Taiwan and it does not have a seat at the United Nations. Despite this, Taiwan has a thriving economy based on mass production and high-tech industries.



INDUSTRY

Once a poor agricultural island, Taiwan has succeeded in developing one of the world’s most successful industrial economies. It is a world exporter of electronic and electrical goods, machinery, textiles, shoes, sports equipment, TV sets, and watches. This huge export trade pays for the oil and other raw materials the economy needs, for Taiwan has few natural resources of its own.

OPERA

Traditional Chinese opera is popular in Taiwan. The basic stories are simple, concerning good against evil, or boy meets girl, and there are few props on stage. Instead, the actor’s movements, elaborate costumes, and facial makeup all convey character and plot.



TRIBAL GROUPS

Long before the Chinese first came to Taiwan, the island was home to a variety of peoples. Each tribe had its own distinct language, but all had many customs and skills in common. In the 1600s, the Chinese came to the island and fought the tribes for control. Today the surviving tribes make up only 2 percent of the total population.



The largest surviving tribe is the Amis, who are expert potters and farmers. The Amis live in large villages, with women holding power in the family home.

TAOISM

The major religions practiced in Taiwan are Buddhism, Taoism, and Confucianism. These faiths are closely linked, and many people follow aspects of all three. Taoism, which began in China around 300 BC, teaches how people can follow the *tao* (path) to a life of simplicity and freedom from desire. Taoists aim to live in harmony with nature, balancing the calm, feminine side of the body (*yin*) with the active, male side (*yang*).



Temples are used as social centers and playgrounds as well as places of worship.

Major tribes in Taiwan

- Tsou
- Paiwan
- Amis
- Atayal
- Bunun



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